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Politics - Hopeful in Valley run quits over suit - Assembly candidate Stevens exits race after allegations tied to 2015 gender-bias settlement

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A candidate seeking to replace a California assemblyman who quit after being accused of mistreating women has quit the race herself after the revelation that she faced a gender-discrimination lawsuit when she was a union executive.

The 2013 suit included the salacious allegation that Samantha Stevens told an employee assigned to attend a meeting with then-L.A. Mayor Antonio Villaraigosa: “We both know that the only reason you’re getting this assignment is that you have bigger boobs.”

In a message emailed to supporters Friday that blamed “dirty politics,” Stevens said she is suspending her campaign for the April 3 special election for the west San Fernando Valley seat vacated by Assemblyman Matt Dababneh, who resigned amid a sexual-misconduct scandal.

Stevens, a political consultant who lives in Reseda, wrote that “two prominent Valley political players” tried to “bully” her into getting out of the race earlier this month when they confronted her with the lawsuit, which has embarrassing implications for a candidate who entered the race in December with a call to female empowerment.

Stevens later said in an interview that the two men are Los Angeles City Councilman Bob Blumenfield and his campaign consultant Larry Levine, who support candidate Tricia Robbins Kasson, a Blumenfield aide and Levine’s client.

Blumenfield and Levine said in interviews that they met with Stevens before Robbins Kasson entered the Assembly District 45 race, and after another potential candidate they favored, L.A. Community College District Trustee Andra Hoffman, opted not to run for the Assembly. They said they approached Stevens as friends and former employers offering helpful advice to leave the race before news of the lawsuit harmed her reputation.

“It’s sad,” said Blumenfield, who said he learned of the lawsuit when copies of court documents arrived at his office by mail from an unknown source. “I don’t know anything about what is or isn’t true, but I know enough about politics to know this isn’t good if you’re running for office in 2018, because this is the year of sexual harassment issues.”

The suit, filed in L.A. County Superior Court by former Service Employees International Union Local 721 political coordinator Rudy Gonzalves

against SEIU, Stevens and others, alleged that Gonzalves was harassed and fired after he complained about discrimination against other employees based on gender, age and family status.

The suit was settled in 2015, and terms were not disclosed. A confidentiality agreement prevented Gonzalves and his attorney from speaking about the case when the Daily News contacted them this week.

In court documents, Gonzalves alleged that Stevens, then the SEIU’s director of governmental relations, assigned employee Susan Naranjo to attend a 2012 meeting with Villaraigosa even though the subject was outside Naranjo’s area of expertise. Gonzalves alleged Stevens told him she had “pimped out” Naranjo at the demand of SEIU President Bob Schoonover, because Schoonover believed Villaraigosa liked “eye candy.”

The suit claimed Naranjo was “devastated at the degradation of being assigned due to her physical attractiveness as if she were chattel, and the subsequent degradation of being referred to as ‘the Villaraigosa girl.’”

Villaraigosa is running for California governor. His campaign did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

The lawsuit separately claimed Stevens judged candidates for jobs and promotions based on their marital and parental status, downgrading those who had families.

Gonzalves claimed he was fired in 2013 because he complained about these and other actions.

Stevens, one of 140 women in California government who signed an open letter in October decrying sexual harassment in the California capital, said in her message to “friends and supporters” Friday that the matter was “an old lawsuit filed against my former employer by a disgruntled employee and, as his supervisor, I had also been named.”

In a phone interview, Stevens said Gonzalves was fired for poor performance and that she wasn’t involved in his dismissal. She said he put her name on the suit because he was angry about bad performance reviews she had given him.

“The accusations in the lawsuit are not true,” said Stevens, who resigned from SEIU in 2015 for reasons she said were unrelated to the lawsuit. She said the decision to settle the suit was made by SEIU and she went along because fighting would have been too expensive.

Saying she had considered herself the front-runner, Stevens said efforts to discredit her because of the lawsuit would make it harder for her to raise the campaign funds she would need to be competitive in April. Last week, the SEIU declined to endorse Stevens or any other candidate in Assembly District 45.

Stevens was one of four Democrats — plus one Republican — who’d filed “statements of intention” to run in the District 45 special election. The Democrats include Robbins Kasson, Jesse Gabriel and Ankur Patel.

“For over 30 years in government and politics, I’ve been inspired by courageous women who have had the determination and foresight to run for office against the odds and make a difference. Now, the time is right for me to join them,” Stevens wrote on her campaign website when she announced her candidacy Dec. 7.

Dababneh resigned Dec. 8, effective Jan. 1, even though he denied sexual misconduct accusations that began with the charge that he cornered lobbyist Pamela Lopez in a Las Vegas bathroom in January 2016 and urged her to touch him as he masturbated.

Earlier, Assemblyman Raul Bocanegra, also a San Fernando Valley Democrat, resigned over sexual harassment allegations amid a widening scandal about powerful men mistreating women in California government.

kmodesti@scng.com @KevinModesti on Twitter

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